

you're playing into their hands. You get a low-cost place to live and they get the dollars they need.

What's a Third World country? For our purposes it's any country with a weak currency. With this definition, Brazil, the eighth largest economy in the world, is in the Third World. So are Spain and Greece, two of history's greatest cultures. So are socialist countries like Hungary and Yugoslavia.

Third World countries sometimes get expensive, but only for short periods. In 1979 and 1980 the world's bankers saw fit to flood Chile, Argentina, and Mexico with hard-currency loans. Billions of dollars, marks, and yen pushed pesos in those countries far beyond their true value. Things got expensive for dollar-based buyers. But the propped-up values collapsed in 1982 when the banks cut back on lending. Now most Latin American currencies are back to their former levels.

WHERE IN THE WORLD TO LIVE

The cost of living is so low, and the thrill of adventure so high, that the question is not whether you should head for the Third World, but what country you should try first. For fun, get a map of the world. Close your eyes and point to a country. Chances are your finger will hover over a place that costs a tiny fraction of what you're spending now. Of all the countries in the world, only two dozen or so are developed. The rest are waiting for you.

So how do you select a country that fits your needs? One way is to consider places you've visited. Does that week in Puerto Vallarta stick in your memory? Do you remain fascinated, after all these years, by the Malaysia you saw as a child? If nothing pops up from the past, what about places your friends or business associates have moved to? You can write them, asking their opinion.

You say your friends live in Gary, Lodi, and Pittsburgh rather than Rio, Bali, or Zagreb? Then put your imagination to work on where you might like to live. Do you think of